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Lonergan's Cognitive Theory: Toward A Critical Human Science

David A. Nordquest

Lonergan's cognitive theory, though generally unknown in the discipline, points the way toward a more concrete understanding of politics through its emphasis on the self-appropriation of our knowing. This article examines the invariant structure or method Lonergan finds in all practical or scientific knowing, the precepts that can be derived from the operations of the mind, the continuity between cognitive and moral self-transcendence, and the different horizons which may confine our knowing. It considers the biases which distort personal and political development, the need for cosmopolis, an informal community which helps to save practicality by transcending it, the methodological natural right which may be derived from norms inherent in our knowing, and the emergent probability of progress or decline set by the stock of insights or oversights operative in a society. It concludes that Lonergan's work makes a substantial contribution to the critical human science he seeks and that it could play a helpful role in unifying the discipline.

By the middle of his career, Eric Voegelin's work on ideological movements had persuaded him "beyond a doubt that the center of a philosophy of politics had to be a theory of consciousness."¹ In seeking a more concrete understanding of personal and political order, a number of contemporary thinkers have found it necessary to become, in Eugene Webb's phrase, "philosophers of consciousness." Notable among them for the breadth and penetration of his analysis is the late Canadian philosopher and theologian Bernard Lonergan. Like the work of Voegelin and of Michael Polanyi, Lonergan's studies of how we come to know, of the patterns of our insights and oversights, point the way "beyond ideology" to what Lonergan calls a critical human science.²

1. Eric Voegelin, *Anamnesis*, trans. Gerhart Niemeyer (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 1978), p. 3.

2. Eugene Webb, *Philosophers of Consciousness* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1988); Dante Germino, *Beyond Ideology* (New York: Harper and Row, 1968); Bernard Lonergan, *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding* (New York: Harper and Row, 1978), p. 236. [Where possible, I will provide the equivalent citation to the *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan*, ed. F. E. Crowe and R. M. Doran (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1988-; 4 vols. to date). Thus *Insight*, p. 236 = CWL 3: 261].

Loneragan's background in theology and the nonpolitical focus of his central work have obscured the relevance of what Frederick Crowe has termed "the Lonergan enterprise" for political science. While a number of studies have explored various political aspects of his thought, these aspects are almost unknown in the discipline and merit additional study. Moreover, a substantial portion of Lonergan's work remains unpublished. Although available at the several Lonergan centers around the world, the coming appearance of these materials in the *Collected Works* will spur further research which will clarify many points of detail.³ Meanwhile, there is a need for a general overview of his cognitional theory, coupled with a discussion of its relevance for political science.

Loneragan's account of cognition is most fully elaborated in *Insight*, a contemporary classic which carefully analyzes examples from mathematics, physics, and common sense to discover a more concrete view of practical and scientific knowing. Lonergan calls the first ten chapters "five-finger exercises," designed to help readers to the required concreteness through a self-appropriation of their own knowing.⁴ In his view, we must come to regard this knowing not statically, as a thing encapsulated in propositions, but as an ongoing process, as a self-assembling dynamic structure which must be experienced, grasped, and critically reflected on to be truly known. To ensure a concrete appre-

3. On the general character of Lonergan's effort, see F. E. Crowe, *The Lonergan Enterprise* (Cambridge: Cowley, 1980). Helpful studies of political implications include Frederick Lawrence, "Political Theology and 'The Longer Cycle of Decline,'" in *Loneragan Workshop II*, ed. F. Lawrence (Chico: Scholars Press, 1978); Robert Doran, "Education for Cosmopolis," *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies* 1: 134-57; Michael Lamb, "The Political and Social Dimensions of Lonergan's Theology," in *The Desires of the Heart* (New York: Paulist Press, 1988); F. E. Crowe, *Bernard Lonergan and the Community of Canadians* (Toronto: Lonergan Institute and Canadian Institute of Jesuit Affairs, 1992); and Mary Ann Glendon, "Comparative Law As Shock Treatment," *Method:JLS* 11: 137-53. Unpublished materials and revised editions of published works are being prepared for publication in the *Collected Works* at the Lonergan Research Institute in Toronto, which generously allows scholars full access to unpublished materials. They maintain a library of printed primary and secondary materials, as well as archives of manuscripts, lecture notes, letters, recordings and other materials.

4. Cathleen Going, ed., *Dialogues in Celebration* (Montreal: Thomas More Institute Press, 1980), p. 295.

hension of our knowing, Lonergan does not base his analysis on a metaphysics, because that "gives rise to endless disputed questions."⁵ Rather he looks directly to the operations of knowing going on within us, operations whose normative character can provide a basis for reaching reasonable judgments in ethics and politics.

Although it has been argued that Lonergan's focus on operations in the knowing subject makes his analysis more properly a "way" or a type of "know-how" than a theory, his analysis is systematic enough and makes intentionality and self-transcendence so central that the label "theory" seems warranted. Lonergan himself calls his account both a way and "something like a theory," apparently thinking the qualification necessary because his account requires a self-appropriation by the reader for which there is no substitute in words—or in a theory of the usual sort.⁶

The implications of Lonergan's account for various subjects are already becoming clear. Lonergan worked out some in *Insight*, *Method in Theology*, and in lectures and writings on education, political economy, natural right, authority, hermeneutics, and other topics.⁷ The large number of Lonergan scholars continue to refine his method and to apply it fruitfully to ever new problems.⁸ Because the concrete appropriation of how we come to know is fundamental for any critical human science, Lonergan's challenging account fully merits the growing attention it is now receiving.

5. Lonergan, "Critical Realism and the Integration of the Sciences," (Toronto: Regis College typescript of Dublin transcript of lectures, 1961), p. 14. For Lonergan's related reinterpretation of St. Thomas, see his *Verbum*, ed. David Burrell (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame, 1967).

6. See: David Burrell, "Method and Sensibility: Novak's Debt to Lonergan," *Journal of the American Academy of Religion*, 40: 349-67; F. E. Crowe, *The Lonergan Enterprise*, pp. 60-62; and Lonergan, *A Second Collection*, ed. F. J. Ryan and B. J. Tyrell (Philadelphia: The Westminster Press, 1974), pp. 213-15.

7. A sample of Lonergan's later writings which nicely illustrates the wide range of his interests is his *Third Collection* (1985). His educational writings have just been published as *Topics in Education* and his economic work will be published soon as *Essay in Circulation Analysis* in the *Collected Works*.

8. Many applications have been published in *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies* and in the volumes of *Lonergan Workshop*, edited by Frederick Lawrence. A continuing bibliography may be found in the *Lonergan Newsletter*, edited by F. E. Crowe and R. M. Doran and published by the Lonergan Research Institute.

The Method of the Human Mind

At the heart of Lonergan's cognitional theory is an account of the method present in all our knowing, a method Lonergan calls transcendental because it is not tied to any particular context or discipline. He finds all knowing taking the form of a dynamic structure, more similar in form to a dance than to a building, a structure composed of operations which are functionally related to each other so that earlier ones prompt, shade into, and are perfected by later ones. Method in this sense is equivalent to "the procedures of the human mind."⁹ The methods employed in various scientific disciplines, and the method of common sense, represent different specializations of this general method of the mind.

The first or empirical stage of this method is that of experience or sensation. This may be preceded by and distinguished from a dreamless sleep or a state such as a coma. Knowing is not, as the naive realist would assert, merely a matter of operations at this level, a case of simply taking a look. Gaping may let visual impressions roll in on our eyes, but "so far from being the beau ideal of human knowing, is just stupidity."¹⁰ Far from being self-contained, sensation usually calls forth an impulse which we may thematize as a question—"what is that?"—to be answered by the operations of the intelligence or understanding which must follow. Gaping is considered a sign of stupidity because it suggests a contentment with sensations, an absence of the intelligence which seeks to know what or why. The empirical stage of knowing is the easiest to grasp because it is the easiest to affect and to distinguish. We have only to open and close our eyes to catch ourselves seeing, for example.

On the succeeding intellectual level, we undertake operations leading to conceptions, definitions, hypotheses and theories—in more general terms, to understanding. Understanding occurs when the "state of wonder" Aristotle distinguished "leads to the formation of images that simplify the sensitive data, that throw it

9. For a summary treatment, see "Cognitional Structure," in *Collection*, ed. F. E. Crowe (New York: Herder and Herder, 1967) = CWL 4; Lonergan, *Method in Theology* (New York: Seabury Press, 1972), p. 4.

10. Lonergan, *Collection*, p. 221 = CWL 4: 206.

into schematic constellations digestible for limited human understanding" through insights.¹¹ This grasp of our experience does not provide us with additional data of sense or consciousness, but with something quite different, with "an intelligible unity or pattern that is, not perceived, but understood" and understood not yet as true but only as possibly relevant.¹² Without experience, there can be no operations on the intellectual level, because there would be nothing to operate on. However, experience plus our attempts to grasp it may constitute thinking, but "thinking isn't the same as knowing."¹³ We get many half-baked ideas, our insights are "a dime a dozen," we concoct many wrong theories. As Lonergan argues, "to omit judgment is quite literally silly: it is only by judgment that there emerges a distinction between fact and fiction, logic and sophistry, philosophy and myth, history and legend, astronomy and astrology, chemistry and alchemy."¹⁴

Before we can be said to know, we have to ask and to judge if something is really the case, and to answer by considering whether it meets the conditions that we can set for its being so. This process occurs when the psyche prompts the imagination "to suggest contrary instances and then favorable instances" and deliberation works to see if our hypotheses withstand the tests.¹⁵ That is, we start out with an object of thought, with a synthesis at the intellectual level of operations. This forms the borrowed content of a judgment. Once we find the conditions we can set for this synthesis fulfilled, once there are no further good questions that we can ask, we can add the proper content of the judgment, the "it is so," and affirm that this or that really is the case.¹⁶

Lonergan argues that we make such affirmations when something becomes "virtually unconditioned." Something absolutely

11. Lonergan, "Critical Realism," p. 19.

12. Lonergan, *The Subject* (Milwaukee: Marquette University Press, 1968), p.

15.

13. Lonergan, "Critical Realism," p. 20.

14. Pierrot Lambert *et al.*, *Caring About Meaning: Patterns in the Life of Bernard Lonergan* (Montreal: Thomas More Institute, 1982), p. 53. All references to this volume are to Lonergan's answers to questions put to him by a panel; Lonergan, "Cognitional Structure," p. 223 = CWL 4: 206-207.

15. Going, *Dialogues*, pp. 286-87.

16. Lonergan, *Understanding and Being*, ed. E. A. and M. D. Morelli (New York: The Edwin Mellen Press, 1980), p. 140 = CWL 5: 114-15.

unconditioned would exist in any and all circumstances. However, once the conditions which make the existence of anything else contingent are fulfilled, it is "as if" the thing were simply unconditioned, for no further conditions remain to make its existence problematical. Lonergan argues that we know when we have sensed, grasped, and judged so as to determine that the possible conditions have all been fulfilled.¹⁷ This view of judgment is similar to Polanyi's and owes much to Newman, the main parts of whose *Grammar of Assent* Lonergan studied repeatedly, but Lonergan's account is more systematic and relates judgment more fully to the cognitional process considered as a whole.¹⁸

The syllogism nicely illustrates the character of the virtually unconditioned:

If A, then B.
But A.
Therefore B.

Because the lone condition for B is fulfilled, its existence is now virtually unconditioned and a judgment *that B* is in order. The reader may object that this example of judgment improperly assumes what it would define, because the major and minor premises are themselves judgments. However, Lonergan argues that there are instances of concrete, primitive judgments which take the same structure and which also deliver a virtually unconditioned. He offers the case of a man who leaves his spic-and-span home in the morning and returns at night to find windows broken, water on the floor, and smoke in the air. He arrives at the judgment: "Something happened." A syllogism could be composed which would yield this conclusion,¹⁹ but Lonergan suggests the concrete judgment would be made somewhat differently. Here, the man would understand the language "something

17. *Insight*, chap. 10.

18. Lonergan, *Second Collection*, p. 38; Lambert, *Caring*, pp. 13-15; 46; Michael Polanyi, *Personal Knowledge* (New York: Harper and Row, 1964); Richard Gelwick, *The Way of Discovery* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1977), pp. 135-36; Lonergan, "True Judgment and Science," a 1929 composition, of which a copy is available at the Lonergan Research Institute.

19. Lonergan, *Understanding and Being*, p. 148-49 = CW 5: 121-22.

happened" to apply when a set of things had been put into a different state. His memory and his new perception of the scene would reveal the changed arrangement and this would lead him to affirm the conclusion, because its condition had been fulfilled. Lonergan argues that similar concrete judgments embodying his analysis of the virtually unconditioned are to be met with in all areas of life.²⁰

Do we in fact come to know in accordance with Lonergan's dynamic, self-assembling structure of experience, understanding, and judgment? Lonergan argues that each of us must consult his or her own experience to determine the answer, but he contends that anyone who honestly does so will be driven to agree that we do. "Not even behaviorists claim that they are unaware whether or not they see or hear, taste or touch. Not even positivists preface their lectures and their books with the frank avowal that never in their lives did they have the experience of understanding anything whatever. Not even relativists claim that never in their lives did they have the experience of making a rational judgment. Not even determinists claim that never in their lives did they have the experience of making a responsible choice."²¹ Such remarks are in order because experience properly grasped and judged is the final appeal in such matters. Indeed, Lonergan tells an interviewer that the verification possible for his "generalized empirical method" is "superior to any of the verification that you can get in science because in science you are not dealing with the immediate data; you are dealing with constructs, with electrons and such things."²² Of course, for us to be dealing with immediate data, we have to consult our own consciousness rather than simply a set of propositions about that consciousness.

What is particularly striking about Lonergan's Transcendental Method is its invulnerability to a fundamental revision, its rock-like character. Details of the cognitional process might, of course, be worked out somewhat more fully or, perhaps, with greater precision. However, to challenge Lonergan's basic account of the structure of knowing, we have to assume it. As he argues, to claim that he had overlooked certain matters assumes

20. *Ibid.*, p.149 = CWL 5: 122; Lonergan, "Critical Realism," pp. 21-22.

21. Lonergan, *Collection*, p. 227 = CWL 4: 210.

22. Lambert, *Caring*, pp. 68, 117.

an experiential level. Any contention that he had misinterpreted or misconceived experience would presuppose the intellectual level at which experience is apprehended—and, by implication, an experiential level requiring intellectual apprehension. To argue that Lonergan's account had failed to fulfill this or that condition necessary for affirming its truth would presuppose the critical or reflective level, that of judgment—along with the intellectual level being judged and the experience conceptualized at the intellectual level. Any criticism, it appears, would presuppose part or all of his account. The practice of critics would even point beyond cognitive transcendence to the moral transcendence considered below. As Lonergan observes, they would undertake such a risky and possibly frustrating venture of refutation "only as a result of a judgment of value and a decision." Their efforts would reflect a view that "it is worth while to get things straight, to know with exactitude, to contribute to the advancement of science."²³ Their action would thus presuppose the succeeding level of responsibility, of deliberation and decision.

This sketch, which is meant to indicate only the main lines of Lonergan's subtle analysis, should strike the reader, who embodies such a process, as not entirely surprising. What counts, though, is not the articulation or acceptance of this or that proposition, but the ability of the analysis to help us catch ourselves in the various acts which together constitute knowing. It is absolutely essential that we grasp the dynamism of this structure, with its impulse to move from one level to the next. When we not only experience this dynamic structure in ourselves, but also grasp it and critically question our grasp until the obscurities and inconsistencies melt away, we will have accomplished what Lonergan terms self-appropriation.

Because knowing is not simply taking a look, we make this appropriation not through introspection, by taking an objectifying look within, but through a process of raising our consciousness repeatedly from experience to understanding to reflective judgment to responsible decision. Central to this self-appropriation is our discovery of ourselves achieving insights, because insights, in "responding to inquiry, grasping intelligible form in

23. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, pp. 18-19.

sensible representations, and grounding the formation of concepts," are the "keystones of knowing."²⁴ According to Lonergan, a full understanding of insights confers "a basic yet startling unity on the whole field of human inquiry and human opinion."²⁵ Insights are central to self-appropriation because they make plain the movement in our knowing and take us beyond a static conceptualism.

Lonergan's most striking instance of insight is the ancient story of Archimedes in the public baths of Syracuse wondering how the composition of a crown might be determined without damaging it. Archimedes notices his body displacing water from the bath, grasps the principle of specific gravity from the image he forms of himself displacing the water, and, conceptualizing the insight, sees its application to his problem with the crown. He is so exhilarated that he runs naked through the city streets shouting "I have found it!"²⁶

Lonergan finds several universal aspects of insights apparent in this vivid example. It shows how insights come as a release to built-up tension, a tension produced by the autonomous force Aristotle calls wonder. The tension that we feel when we are seeking to understand is the physiological counterpart to the intentionality and the drive toward completion inherent in our "pure desire to know." This dynamism leads us to insights which are "ecstatic," in the sense that they take us out of the existing texture of our thinking, insights which come suddenly and unexpectedly and which, because of the different understanding they provide, will never flow from an automatic or routine following of precepts or recipes. Because insights are achievements, they require both native intelligence, the tool for the job, and attentiveness and application, the effective use of the tool. Insights therefore depend more on inner than on outer conditions. Insights pivot between the concrete and the abstract, in that they depend on particular images, but make possible acts of abstraction which formulate relations of general significance. Once achieved, insights pass "into the habitual texture of one's mind," so that it is

24. Lonergan, *The Subject*, p. 9.

25. *Insight*, p. x = CWL 3: 3.

26. *Ibid.*, p. 3 = CWL 3: 27.

no longer possible to look at things quite the same way as before.²⁷

According to Lonergan, having an insight "is not a matter of comparing abstract concepts and deciding that they are necessarily conjoined. . . . It has nothing to do with abstract concepts; it is understanding in the image."²⁸ (This is not to say that symbols could not serve as images of concepts and thereby facilitate insights into the logic of their relations.) Still, once insights into images are achieved, the insights are conceptualized and definitions, hypotheses, postulates, and theories are formed. However, it is critical to remark that insights precede the formulations, which make sense only in relation to the insights they formulate. Failure to grasp this is the major defect of what Lonergan terms the theoretical horizon, as we shall see below.

The reader might wonder whether the precedence of insight over concept is not simply a matter of guesswork or whether it has any practical significance. Here Lonergan's seemingly esoteric mathematical examples show their value. He argues that some mathematical proofs, such as certain of Euclid's demonstrations, are not logically rigorous, but depend for their persuasive force on insights that are not formalized in the demonstrations. Since Euclid formalized whatever he was aware of conceptualizing, this goes far toward establishing that acts of insight and understanding may occur without the use of inner words or concepts.²⁹ Although Polanyi does not formulate his account of personal knowledge so explicitly on this point, his emphasis on the tacit dimension in knowing suggests something like Lonergan's notion of acts of understanding in the image, rather than in the concept.³⁰ This distinction is central to Lonergan's thought because it underlies his criticism of the classicist outlook, his endorsement of the perspective of the critical subject over that of the theoretical subject, and his development of a new, methodological natural right to replace the old, conceptualist, deductivist version, topics to which we shall turn later.

27. Eric O'Connor, ed., *Curiosity At the Center of One's Life* (Montreal: Thomas More Institute, 1987), p. 374; *Insight*, pp. 5-6 = CWL 3: 28-31.

28. Lonergan, "Critical Realism," p. 2.

29. Lonergan, *Second Collection*, p. 269; "Critical Realism," pp. 2-5; *Understanding and Being*, pp. 26-29 = CWL 5: 23-26; *Method in Theology*, p. 213 n.63.

30. Polanyi, *The Tacit Dimension* (Garden City: Doubleday, 1967).

The inherent intentionality of our knowing is most strikingly evident in the straining for an insight anyone who has wrestled with a puzzle is familiar with. However, similar impulses forward can be found at each level of the cognitional process and Lonergan suggests we can thematize them in a series of questions. When the senses present us with one or another experiential content, our intelligence greets it "with the perplexity, the wonder, the drive, the intention" that may be represented by the questions "What is it? Why is it so?" (The impulse does not "consist in" such questions because it is pre-conceptual.) The questions make evident an inner movement—here, a process of inquiry that leads us to define, postulate, suppose, hypothesize, theorize. Following these intellectual operations, critical rationality is called into play, a process whose impulse can be thematized in the new questions "Is that so? Are you certain?" Lonergan concludes that this process, too, is objective because it is intentional: "All marshalling and weighing of evidence, all judging and doubting, are efforts to say of what is that it is and of what is not that it is not. Accordingly, the dynamic structure of human knowing intends being." Because our questioning knows no bounds, it intends a comprehensive knowledge of the universe, an unrestricted scope Lonergan thematizes as "the notion of being."³¹

The naive realist—most of us—may suspect that the various operations associated with understanding and judgment are immanent and can therefore tell us nothing about objects. Lonergan argues that such doubters are guilty of what he terms "picture-thinking," a vice which afflicts the doctrines of philosophers of various schools. Lonergan thinks even Kant succumbed. The problem, he believes, is that naive realists attend to their own sensations but do not undertake the job of appropriating the other stages of their knowing. Lonergan argues, however, that "visual images are incapable of representing or suggesting the normative exigences of intelligence and reasonableness and, much less, their power to effect the intentional self-transcendence of the subject." More vividly, "insight is not optical."³² A fuller self-appropriation of our knowing is required, one which Lonergan, in a passage

31. Lonergan, *Collection*, p. 228 = CWL 4: 211; *The Subject*, pp. 11-12.

32. Lonergan, *The Subject*, pp. 14-17; Lambert, *Caring*, p. 52.

which recalls Plato's Allegory of the Cave, refers to as "a matter of conversion, of a personal philosophical experience, of moving out of a world of sense and of arriving, dazed and disoriented for a while, into a universe of being."³³

Self-Transcendence

The intentionality of human knowing takes us beyond being "locked up" in ourselves.³⁴ A limited self-transcendence is evident already in our sensations, but this transcendence develops and expands as we attempt to grasp what we sense and then to judge whether what we have grasped is actually so. As Lonergan remarks of judgment, "when you say: 'this is so', you are affirming something that is independent of you. You are self-transcending."³⁵

Alongside this cognitive self-transcendence there is a moral transcendence which recognizes the value in things outside us: "moral conversion is being guided by values rather than by satisfactions," Lonergan maintains. The "values" he has in mind are defined, in part, by their transcendence of our own pleasure or pain. We transcend ourselves in recognizing that what we value transcends us, that it can be assessed apart from its ability to serve us. When we move from recognizing value independent of us to acting according to our recognition, we achieve a fuller moral transcendence, one that has us "doing what is truly good," instead of being "merely out for your own interest."³⁶

Operations at the deliberative level of consciousness, at which value is assessed, are continuous with those on the cognitive levels because the "rationally self-conscious subject" finds in himself "an exigence for consistency between his knowing and his doing." This exigence arises from the "identity of consciousness" at the levels of intelligence, reflection, and deliberation. Lonergan argues that while "sensitive desires and aversions arise spontaneously, their objects cannot be willed until they are subsumed under some intelligible order." Our actions and their consequences

33. Lonergan, *The Subject*, p. 18. Compare Plato's *Republic* vii, 514a-518d.

34. Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, p. 104.

35. O'Connor, *Curiosity*, p. 394.

36. *Ibid.*, p. 395.

have to be related to the hierarchy of intelligible orders which form our knowledge and there is an inner pressure that this relation be consistent. Thus, we see that it is not consistent to choose the part, the antecedent, or the conditioned, while repudiating the associated whole, consequent, or conditions. Our varied efforts to ward off this pressure for consistency by avoiding self-knowledge, by rationalizing our knowledge to fit our deeds, or by pleading incapacity attest to the existence of the exigence. In such cases, we glimpse the questionable character of our enterprises and so would not wish to carry our understanding of ourselves or of our circumstances so far as to make our moral inconsistency obvious.³⁷

Lonerган regards deliberation and decision as constituting "the most fundamental, the most decisive, the highest" level of consciousness, because it is at this moral level that we decide, will, and thereby determine what sort of persons we will be.³⁸ Our potential for moral self-transcendence is made possible and compelling by a being-in-love which, like Plato's eros, has the therapeutic results of promoting openness and of obviating the need for repression.³⁹ The movement evident in the earlier stages of the cognitional process either facilitates, prefigures, or already is this love. Thus Lonergan refers to "the unconscious eros . . . constantly expressing itself on all these levels, directing your attention, forming suggestive images." (The directing metaphor suggests the eros may be external to cognition, the forming metaphor that it is consubstantial with it.) He sees the eros terminating "at the *depassement de soi* which is being in love," a love whose widening scope he sketches as "the domestic love of the family, the urban or national or universal love of mankind, and the love of God, which pulls you out of the finite universe."⁴⁰ While the seeming continuity of the eros and drive for self-transcendence does not prove that its final end was its original end and cause,

37. *Insight*, pp. 618, 601, 599-600 = CWL 3: 641, 624, 622-23.

38. O'Connor, *Curiosity*, pp. 371-72.

39. Robert Cushman, *Therapeia: Plato's Conception of Philosophy* (Westport: Greenwood Press, 1976); Lamb, "Political and Social Dimensions in Lonergan's Theology," pp. 270, 277.

40. Going, *Dialogues*, p. 310.

the continuity is suggestive and argues for a religious openness.

Loneragan does not fully explain the relation of the falling in love which prompts or constitutes moral self-transcendence to the cognitional process presented above. As Frederick Crowe has argued, the later Lonergan distinguished two fundamental movements in consciousness—from below up, from experience to understanding to judgment to recognition of value, and from above down, from affectivity, including love, to valuing to belief to a richer experiencing. The second process is of great importance, but Crowe thinks it necessary to extend Lonergan's notion of value to flesh out the relation of the two movements.⁴¹ This is a large problem in Lonergan studies, but it is not the focus of the present article. In any case, the richer experiencing prompted by love must itself be grasped and critically judged according to transcendental method, so the second process is by no means an alternative to the first.

Horizons

Although everyone can find within his or her knowing the same general method of the human mind, our knowing becomes specialized according to the needs of our circumstances, resulting in our acquiring characteristic horizons, which set limits to what we can know. Everyday life, and most of political life, takes the perspective of common sense. Its concern is intensely practical—how to get what, when, and how—and its practitioners have little or no inclination to put aside matters at hand in order to develop theories immediately important only for their truthfulness. Common-sense subjects know particular persons and particular places, in the sense that they know what to say to whom and how it is appropriate to act here or there. Their knowing does not become independent of their affections, feelings, and wants, however. They know things in relation to themselves, but not, like the scientist, in relation to each other. Common sense therefore consists of “an incomplete set of insights,” which must be “completed differently in each concrete situation.”⁴² It continually adapts

41. F. E. Crowe, “An Expansion of Lonergan's Notion of Value,” in *Loneragan Workshop VII*, ed. Fred Lawrence (Atlanta: Scholars Press, 1988).

42. *Insight*, p. 211 = CWL 3: 236; Lonergan, “Critical Realism,” pp. 35-40.

to new situations and so is not capable of systematization. Its characteristic expression is the proverb and frequently its articulations are at odds, as "look before you leap" opposes, while complementing, "he who hesitates is lost." Common-sense views are not restricted to the man on the street. Some scientists, including, perhaps, some political scientists, approach their work with a similarly practical outlook, as do many students. When such persons encounter theory, they try to translate it into the language of common sense.⁴³

Lonerган's theoretical subject, on the other hand, puts feelings, practical concerns, and decisions aside and concentrates simply on knowing.⁴⁴ Thus the scientist Richard Feynman could speak of "committing suicide" for six months in order to find out the cause of the Challenger disaster.⁴⁵ Although this putting aside of one's everyday life is crucial for the building up of science and culture, the theoretical outlook can also foster oversights.

The theoretical subject may naively take terms and concepts to be self-subsistent, independent of acts of understanding. Writing "makes language an object for eye as well as ear" and, by increasing the accessibility of language, facilitates the development of grammar, logic, and rhetoric. Such second-level uses of language are exploited by philosophers to "develop technical terms for speaking compendiously about anything that can be spoken about."⁴⁶ However, the accessibility that permits such developments also makes language more remote from acts of understanding and tempts us to overemphasize propositions, logic and a conceptualistic metaphysics. The theoretic mind thus finds alluring the classicist and conceptualist notions of fixed concepts and permanent cultures, having "never imagined that the meaning of terms varied with the acts of understanding that they expressed."⁴⁷ When the notion of permanent meanings as basic premises becomes popularized, we may get, in Eric

43. Lonergan, "Critical Realism," pp. 45, 47.

44. *Ibid.*, p. 37.

45. Richard Feynman, *What Do You Care What Other People Think?* (New York: Bantam Books, 1989), pp. 116-18.

46. Lonergan, *A Third Collection*, ed. F. E. Crowe (New York: Paulist Press, 1985), p. 177.

47. Lonergan, *Philosophy of God and Theology* (London: Darton: Longman and Todd, 1973), p. ix.

O'Connor's words, "a deformation of common sense in the expectation of deductivist systems," resulting in widespread proposition-mongering.⁴⁸ Religious experience may be diluted by conceptualism, as well, if we forget that, in prayer, "the diminution and at times the disappearance of symbols and concepts of God" accompanies spiritual advance.⁴⁹

Lonergan offers three reasons for the theoretical subject's tendency to emphasize conceptualism and deductivism over existential realities. First, because truths have been discovered which are virtually unconditioned, the lack of remaining conditions may make them appear to reside in "a realm that is non-spatial, atemporal, impersonal." Lonergan calls this "a conceptualist extrinsicism for which concepts have neither dates nor developments and truth is so objective that it gets along without minds." However, the formulations of truth make sense only in relation to the acts of understanding which formulate them. Insights, as we have seen, are into images and precede concepts. The second cause, the Aristotelian ideal of truth as proceeding necessarily from self-evident premises, has similar consequences. The formality of the inferences promotes neglect of the need "for concern with the subject, for the maieutic art of Socrates, for intellectual conversion, for open-mindedness, striving, humility, perseverance." The third reason the subject is neglected is "the metaphysical account of the soul." In treating the soul in terms of "potencies, habits, acts, objects," an objective, universal description is provided, but the result is not existentially consequential: "we have souls whether we are awake or asleep, saints or sinners, geniuses or imbeciles."⁵⁰ In each of these cases, what we may call ungrounded theory neglects what is substantial or operating in our nature.

Lonergan contends that Enlightenment thought popularized the rationalistic neglect of the subject, but he argues that modern science and critical philosophy have learned that operations on concepts are inadequate, that "anything deductive is marking time." Conceptual manipulations may seem well-grounded, because fixed concepts appear implicit in practical and scientific

48. Going, *Dialogues*, p. 288.

49. Lonergan, *Second Collection*, p. 29.

50. *Ibid.*, p. 30; Lonergan, *The Subject*, pp. 2-7.

language, but the meaning of the concepts depends on the subject's insights. For this reason, Lonergan concludes that "logic does not have positive results in the long run," but simply "eliminates blunders." By dealing in terms and ignoring the subject, the theoretical outlook makes itself vulnerable to a floating deductivism which consists of "just arranging your concepts."⁵¹

Lonergan thinks "critical questions and answers" to be "beyond the theoretic horizon" and offers as an illustration the likely response of a theoretic mind to the argument considered above: "'An account of one's knowledge that can be verified only in one's own personal experience? Well, what on earth does that mean? Aren't there any proofs? Aren't there any demonstrations?'" The problem, Lonergan argues, is that the theoretical subject thinks only in terms of objects and cannot grasp the possibility that cognitional activity might be known directly, as operating.⁵² Not grasping that, he or she will not achieve a concrete account of knowing, but will instead fall under the spell of this or that verbal formula.

Beyond the theoretical view is the critical or the methodological, which looks to human understanding in process rather than to the logical manipulation of concepts. Concentration on the operations of knowing gives the critical subject a historical, developmental view of meaning and makes him or her sensitive to the variability of common sense, aware of the contextual horizons we may be inhabiting. This contextual awareness differs from that of common sense because it is reflective and wider, and it gives the critical subject a better chance of accurately understanding others. This horizon transcends historicism because the critical subject grasps the permanent exigences inherent in the operations of knowing—the attentiveness required in experiencing, the intelligence required for understanding, the reasonableness which grounds critical judgment, and the responsibility required in deliberation and decision.⁵³ Because the self-appropriation of their knowing defines critical subjects, such subjects will bear a marked intellectual resemblance to Lonergan himself.

51. O'Connor, *Curiosity*, p. 382; Lambert, *Caring*, pp. 230, 245; Lonergan, *The Subject*, pp. 9-12; Going, *Dialogues*, p. 288.

52. Lonergan, "Critical Realism," pp. 45-46.

53. *Ibid.*, pp. 40-43.

These differences in horizon have important political consequences. Lonergan suggests that the spontaneous, common-sense subject "looks upon the rest of men" outside his or her group "as mere foreigners" and he argues convincingly that differences in common sense are one of the most significant causes of misunderstandings and political conflict.⁵⁴ The theoretical subject, taking a wider view, develops universal norms and "tries to get the League of Nations or the United Nations to realize these ideal norms in human society to some extent."⁵⁵ That may appear all well and good, but, in an interview, Lonergan suggests this same noncontextual outlook is to blame for misjudgments such as prohibition: "it is bad, so we will prevent it" may be the overly abstract approach.⁵⁶ Lonergan's great appreciation for Jane Jacobs, whom he called "Mrs. Insight," was surely due in considerable part to her criticism of urban renewers for their rationalistic neglect of the context within which they were operating, of the living neighborhoods they were destroying.⁵⁷ The critical subject, however, as existential and self-aware, is mindful of social and historical context, and aware that what is central to human order is not abstract norms but the processes in subjects from which the norms are derived and from which they gain their weight and meaning. Such persons appreciate the accepted answers to the great questions for deliberation, but look more to the questioning which meets issues squarely and to the deliberating which seeks fully the responsibility only roughly embodied in codes. In relativizing codes, the critical subject does not seek excuses for moral laxness, but escape from simple manipulations of formulas that obscure complexities and forestall more responsible action.

After considering Lonergan's account of the polity and common sense, we will consider how such a methodological view can be applied to natural right and help avoid problems often attributed to such views.

54. Lonergan, *Understanding and Being*, pp. 110-111 = CWL 5: 91.

55. Lonergan, "Critical Realism," p. 42.

56. O'Connor, *Curiosity*, p. 382.

57. Jane Jacobs, *The Death and Life of Great American Cities* (New York: Vintage Books, 1961).

Insights, Bias, and the Polity

Lonerган situates human life and the polity in the context of the operation of emergent probability. The idea is simply that in nature the probability of more complex schemes of recurrence will depend on the occurrence of the less complex schemes which constitute their conditions. Complex organizations depend upon simpler organizations, we may say. In human society the same dependence holds, but the intervention of intelligence means that insights, too, play a role, that the occurrence of more complex insights is conditioned by the occurrence of simpler ones. This is itself an insight of fundamental importance for political science. It means that, as human societies progress, their future development comes to depend less on material conditions and more on the stock of operative insights and oversights.⁵⁸

There is an emergent probability of progress when insights are recurring and are becoming effective, because they then create conditions which permit more advanced insights, to round out the reasonableness already on display. Similarly, a failure to recognize social problems is important not only for its own sake but also for its effects in repressing other insights. When a social situation develops arbitrarily, when compromises are added to compromises until no one can see any order in the results, there is nothing to round off.⁵⁹ Lonergan observes that "the more the objective situation becomes a mere dump, the less is there any possibility of human intelligence gathering from the situation anything more than a lengthy catalog of the aberrations and follies of the past."⁶⁰ The social situation then no longer operates as a heuristic device, no longer fosters insights, but instead breeds despair and oversights. So emergent probability may bring either progress or decline, as conditions are created which make either further insights or oversights more probable. Plato, in quite different language, offers a similar account of the gathering momentum of political decline in books 8 and 9 of the *Republic*.

Lonerган's treatment of the biases that derail cognition and promote oversights and decline is presented in the context of an

58. *Insight*, pp. 210-11 = CWL 3: 235-36.

59. *Ibid.*, p. 229 = CWL 3: 254.

60. Lonergan, *Third Collection*, p. 105.

interesting genetic account of the origins of politics and political thought. He suggests the first human communities began at the level of pure intersubjectivity and were rooted in schemes of recurrence similar to those present in animal life, fostering a sense of belonging which provided the "dynamic premise" for common endeavors. Lonergan contends anyone can find evidence of the power of intersubjectivity in his or her own simple reactions: if "something is going at your head, you move up your arm, but if something is going to hit someone else, you also do the same. With equal spontaneity!"⁶¹ Politically, the power of this intersubjectivity remains strong and pervasive "when motley states name themselves nations, when constitutions are attributed to founding fathers, when image and symbol, anthem and assembly, emotion and sentiment are invoked to impart an elemental vigor and pitch to the vast and cold, technological, economic, and political structures of human invention and convention."⁶²

The common endeavors of early intersubjective communities stimulated the development of common sense, as a specialized, but unreflective, form of intelligence adapted to dealing with our relations to things and to our associates. The advent of capital and new technologies produced new economic arrangements requiring more organized, political responses. A specialized political common sense developed to seek the necessary agreements through what de Jouvenal has called "the rallying of wills."⁶³ In seeking to be effective, political leadership developed a stock of practical insights that enabled it to determine "when to push for full performance and when to compromise, when delay is wisdom and when it spells disaster, when widespread consent must be awaited and when action must be taken in spite of opposition." Such practical insights were required for it "to be able to command attention and to win confidence, to set forth concretely the essentials of a case, to make its own decisions and secure the agreement of others, to initiate and carry through some section of that seriation of social responses meeting social challenges that

61. O'Connor, *Curiosity*, p. 388.

62. *Insight*, p. 212 = CWL 3: 238.

63. Bertrand de Jouvenal, *Sovereignty*, trans. J. F. Huntington (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1963), pp. 17-25.

Arnold Toynbee in his *Study of History* has so lavishly and brilliantly illustrated."⁶⁴

Though society is rooted in intersubjectivity, when humans begin to reflect on their society and to raise the question of nature vs. convention, they become aware of their practical intelligence, of their ability to give the polity and the economy a variety of forms. Good is no longer simply what each desires, for persons now apprehend the good of order, the concrete schemes of recurrence through which the common good is advanced. Deliberate reforms ensue and insights give rise to further insights as the situation is gradually made more intelligent and therefore more intelligible: progress occurs. Unfortunately, oversights may also occur and increase the scope of the social surd, that subset of the social arrangements which is unintelligible, prompting further oversights and political decline.⁶⁵

Lonerган finds us subject to four biases which provoke these oversights. The first, the bias of the dramatic subject, is rooted in depth psychology and occurs when "elementary passions bias understanding in practical and personal matters," leading successively to oversights, behavior misunderstood both by others and by ourselves, a defensive withdrawal within, and a division of the person into a persona for presentation to others and an ego "that in the day-dream is at once the main actor and the sole spectator."⁶⁶

The second bias, that of egoism, is traced to the tension and dialectic between intersubjective spontaneity and practical intelligence. Spontaneous actions and feelings tie us together in intersubjective groups, while our intelligence looks beyond to seek wider schemes of cooperation. Egoism manifests itself when the fears and desires which are part of our spontaneity make us incapable of "the self-abnegation involved in allowing complete free play to intelligent inquiry." It is not that egoism is simply an innocent fruit, though. There is a cunning in the development of an intelligence which has a sharp eye for avoiding what we fear and for seizing what we desire, while somehow failing to notice

64. *Insight*, p. 209 = CWL 3: 234.

65. *Ibid.*, pp. 209-214 = CWL 3: 234-39.

66. *Ibid.*, p. 191 = CWL 3: 214; Lamb, "Political and Social Dimensions of Lonergan's Theology," pp. 270-75.

the possible consequences, such as whether our actions could be generalized, whether they are compatible with social order. Such selective inattention helps the egoist to avoid the exigence for consistency between his knowing and doing. A habit develops, so that "it is not by sheer inadvertence but also by a conscious self-orientation that he [the egoist] devotes his energies to sizing up the social order, ferreting out its weak points and its loop-holes, and discovering devices that give access to its rewards while evading its demands for proportionate contributions." Egoism is, then, "an incomplete development of intelligence," repressed from within.⁶⁷

The intersubjectivity of group members gives rise to a third bias which Lonergan terms group bias. When practical intelligence conceives novel schemes of cooperation, new adaptations of sensitivity develop around the new structures, producing a group ethos which shapes and facilitates behavior, but which also encourages a bias against other ways and groups. Insights coinciding with the interests of the group will tend to gain a favorable reception, others to be repressed. Group bias produces what Bergson termed closed societies, because of the inertia and strength of group sensitivity and expectations.⁶⁸ The interests of the group seem to members to require extra solicitude and, as each group thinks in this way, "some part of the energies of all groups is diverted to the superogatory activity of devising and implementing offensive and defensive mechanisms."⁶⁹ Because success in the struggle for advantage makes further successes more likely, classes emerge and social development is distorted. Lonergan's whole analysis is strikingly parallel to Madison's in *Federalist*, No. 10. What is particularly novel and interesting about it is its helpful emphasis on the fundamental role of insights and oversights in community and group dynamics.

The fourth type of bias is the general bias of common sense. Because of its intense practicality, common sense lacks a self-critical dimension. It fails to see that it is only one of the several

67. *Insight*, pp. 220-21 = CWL 3: 245-47; Lamb, "Political and Social Dimensions of Lonergan's Theology," pp. 267-69.

68. Henri Bergson, *The Two Sources of Morality and Religion*, trans. R. Ashley Audra and Cloudesley Brereton (New York: Holt, 1935).

69. *Insight*, p. 224 = CWL 3: 249.

necessary specializations of knowing and, thinking itself self-sufficient, falls prey to shortsightedness and to rationalizations of thoughtlessness. Uncorrected, its immanent outlook makes oversights and decline inevitable.

Lonerган attributes a shorter and a longer cycle of decline to group bias and the general bias of common sense. Group bias alone produces the shorter cycle, one limited in time because the exploitation by the in-group threatens the interests of the out-groups and generates corrective action by them. Although self-limited, such exploitation may come to be rationalized by common sense as normal, since "everybody does it" when they get the chance. "I seen my opportunities and I took 'em," as Plunkitt of Tammany Hall put it. Such rationalizations may be dressed up as pluralist theories condoning serial exploitation or, alternately, submerged in liberal theories of progress blind to evidences of decline. When such practical and theoretical oversights prevail, the longer cycle of decline begins. The situation-bound knowledge of common sense is unable to resist because it lacks the perspective needed to detect anachronistic or anomalous features of social life. Because it is contextual, common sense becomes ever more inept as the situation that confines it becomes less and less intelligible. Eventually, "the only discernable intelligibility" it can find "is an equilibrium of economic pressures and a balance of national powers."⁷⁰

Lonerган sees a needed counterweight to the general bias of common sense in what he terms "cosmopolis," the informal community of those who reject a narrow practicality and who see "that intelligence contains its own immanent norms and that these norms are equipped with sanctions which man does not have to invent or impose." Such citizens thus achieve a higher, more critical viewpoint and by adhering to and fostering ideas and insights without the backing of power and force help to dispel the prejudice that only power counts.⁷¹

From Lonergan's perspective, the conception of our discipline as a study of the pursuit of power or of the application of procedurally correct force is another instance of failure to tran-

70. *Ibid.*, p. 229 = CWL 3: 254.

71. *Ibid.*, pp. 234, 239 = CWL 3: 259, 264.

scend the bias of common sense. Properly viewed, such a conception reflects the spread of social decline into the ranks of those whose function includes the diagnosis of decline. In Lonergan's view, the particular misdeeds of the reigning in-group are, in the long run, less dangerous than this "erection of their sinning into universal principles."⁷² The political scientists of "cosmopolis" would take care not to conceive of or to analyze politics as if only power counted. They would look in addition for patterns of the intelligible and unintelligible, the reasonable and unreasonable, the responsible and the irresponsible, drawing on norms immanent in the cognitional process. They, and like-minded thinkers, would debunk myths, unmask falsifications, "satirize the catchwords and the claptrap," and uncover the roots of the present situation. They would undertake "a withdrawal from practicality to save practicality."⁷³ When decline has proceeded far enough, however, such efforts may be ineffectual and the only cure may be redemptive suffering or sacrifice.⁷⁴

Natural Right

Cognitional theory offers an effective means of harmonizing natural right with both historicity and modern science. Lonergan's attempt at a reconciliation with history begins by distinguishing two ways of conceiving of human nature: first, abstractly or theoretically, as something embodied (or disembodied?) in self-evident truths or universal propositions and, second, critically or methodologically, as something concretely operating, something which implements itself in the cognitional process examined above.⁷⁵ Conceiving of our nature as concretely operating lets us view natural right as "the inmost core of our being," as the exigences we may discover driving the cognitional process.⁷⁶

Identifying our nature with a process rather than with a fixed content provides both transcendent standards and scope for de-

72. *Ibid.*, p. 239 = CWL 3: 264.

73. *Ibid.*, pp. 240-241 = CWL 3: 265-67.

74. Lonergan, *Understanding and Being*, pp. 328-29 = CWL 5: 374-75.

75. Lonergan, *Third Collection*, p. 172.

76. *Ibid.*, p. 182; Frank Paul Braio, "Lonergan's Recovery of the Notion of Natural Right," *Vera Lex* 10 (1990): 4-5, 10.

velopment. If "the source of natural right lies in the norms immanent in human intelligence, human judgment, human evaluation, human affectivity," norms requiring that we be attentive, intelligent, reasonable, responsible, and benevolent, then a study of the operating of our minds will demonstrate that a human being "is committed not by any decision of his own but by nature to intelligent behaviour." We will come to see that "the individual is intelligent and so he cannot enjoy peace of mind unless he subsumes his own feelings and actions under general rules that he regards as intelligent," this because of the "identity of consciousness" already considered.⁷⁷ Because "every person is an embodiment of natural right," who can reveal his or her "natural propensity to seek understanding, to judge reasonably, to evaluate fairly, to be open to friendship," the evidence for natural right is all around us.⁷⁸ The naturalness of these propensities provides the fixed method of natural right, while their character as operations rather than code gives ample room for development.

Such a conception meshes nicely with Aristotle's definition of nature as an immanent principle of movement and rest. Lonergan argues that the basic questions by which we may thematize the cognitional process represent principles of movement and the corresponding answers principles of rest. The questions—what is it? are you sure? is it good?—might seem to suggest something like the old faculty psychology, but it is operations that are involved and they are interdependent and cumulative and appear to be "aspects of something richer and fuller," something "deeper and more comprehensive . . . that begins before consciousness, unfolds through sensitivity, intelligence, rational reflection, responsible deliberation," ending up in "being-in-love, a dynamic state that sublates all that goes before."⁷⁹ Self-transcendence, so conceived, is the heart of our nature and the ground of a tenable primary natural right.

Because the tendency toward self-transcendence is a potential and not a fact, the community which is one possible result of self-

77. Lonergan, *Third Collection*, p. 176; *Insight*, p. 215 = CWL 3: 241.

78. Lonergan, *Third Collection*, p. 182.

79. *Ibid.*, pp. 172, 174; Lonergan, "Natural Right and Historical Mindedness" (abstract), in *Program: Fifty First Annual Meeting* (Washington: American Catholic Historical Society, 1977).

transcendence "is not a necessity of nature but an achievement of man."⁸⁰ Its realization depends on observance of the transcendental precepts: if we are attentive, intelligent, reasonable, and responsible, we will build successful polities, economies, communities. If we appropriate our own knowing, we will find standards for judging by these precepts and will be equipped to detect authenticity and inauthenticity in the manifold of patterns evident in human life. From such a perspective, history may be seen as a course of human achievements and failings, as a great dialectic with movements back and forth between attentiveness and inattention, intelligence and obtuseness, truth and error, recognition of values and pursuit of mere satisfactions. This dialectic may be viewed as an unintended experiment testing a society's way of living and revealing, through the pattern of successes and failures, human nature writ large and what is right by nature.⁸¹

Lonergan's cognitional theory also facilitates the reconciliation of natural right and natural science. As a formulation of the exigences that underlie any knowing, including that in the natural sciences, natural right can hardly be portrayed as contradicting the natural sciences.⁸² To the extent it is derived from the same source, from the same method of the human mind that underlies the natural sciences, to that extent its foundation is equally sure.

There are rather striking similarities between Lonergan's general approach to natural right and the views of Eric Voegelin. Voegelin holds that what counts in moral decisions is not the establishment of rules, but a sensitivity of the *spoudaios* to the good at stake, a sensitivity made possible by an experience of the divine ground of being. He therefore sees the morally mature person rather than rules as the standard for good conduct.⁸³ Lonergan takes a similar view in arguing that "the good is never an abstraction" and in looking to being-in-love, especially with God, as the basis for the sensitivity which promotes unconstrained

80. Lonergan, *Third Collection*, p. 170.

81. *Ibid.*, pp. 176-82.

82. For an interesting argument on the importance of accurate scientific knowledge in moral deliberation, see "Letter of Bernard Lonergan on contraception and the natural law," ed. F. E. Crowe and R. M. Doran, *The Lonergan Newsletter*, 11: 7-8.

83. Voegelin, *Anamnesis*, p. 65.

thought and willing recognition of value.⁸⁴ Like Voegelin, Lonergan holds that "the criterion of judgment of value is the good conscience of a virtuous man," so "you have ethics insofar as you have good people."⁸⁵ Both philosophers of consciousness therefore regard the operations of consciousness as the immediate source of order in society.

However, although Lonergan, like Voegelin, rejects the idea of "an objective code of ethics out there" waiting to be intuited, he argues that a code could be constructed by attending to the exigences of the cognitional process.⁸⁶ Presumably, such a code would amount to a fleshing out of the implications of the transcendental precepts—be attentive, be intelligent, be reasonable, be responsible—for various contingencies. It would, however, have to be regarded as somewhat tentative, because the original transcendental precepts would take precedence, in cases of doubt, over the derivations made from them. Still, Lonergan is open to the idea of such a code, whereas Voegelin worries that codes mediating between the divine source of order and our decisions would come to function as idols.

Importance for Political Science

Lonergan advocates the development of a new, more critical human science based on cognitional theory. In his view, by understanding our own knowing as operating, we go far toward understanding ourselves and toward learning to distinguish liberty and bias, progress and decline, and, as might be said, the goodness and badness of social and political arrangements. Such an advance seems possible to Lonergan only if we discard a nineteenth-century mechanistic view of science and society in favor of the more adequate view of emergent probability, a view which takes full account of the fundamental importance of insights and oversights in political development. As Lonergan remarks, building this critical human science will not be easy: "this is a tall order for human science as it hitherto has existed." Still, "people looking for easy tasks had best renounce any ambition to

84. Lonergan, *Third Collection*, p. 104.

85. O'Connor, *Curiosity*, p. 408.

86. Lonergan, *Second Collection*, p. 39.

be scientists; and if mathematicians and physicists can surmount their surds, the human scientist can learn to master his."⁸⁷

Lonergan's work is itself an impressive contribution to a political science so conceived. Its careful analysis of consciousness shows how the transcendental precepts—be attentive, be intelligent, be reasonable, and be responsible—may be derived from the method of the human mind. These precepts provide a sound basis for justifying the more particular standards with which we may responsibly evaluate regimes and policies. Besides this foundational value, Lonergan's analysis has a useful heuristic role. Its general account of common sense and of the operations and biases which contribute to insight and oversight, to progress and decline, suggest a wealth of particular studies. Each institution and community has its own pattern of common sense, its own emergent probabilities, characteristic horizon, influential insights and oversights. Such features are a fundamental part of political life and could be described, analyzed, and put into proper perspective more systematically and more concretely using Lonergan's terms. His critical analysis of the longer cycle of decline initiated by the general bias of common sense also suggests a more fundamental reevaluation of pluralism and of other power-centered theories, a reevaluation questioning not merely disparities in power, but reliance on power as the standard for analysis, a standard which, in its complacency and excessive practicality, prolongs the general bias of common sense. The parallels between Lonergan's analysis and that of the *Federalist* should prove highly interesting, as well, to students of American politics generally and of the Founding, in particular. The parallels suggest both the political quality of Lonergan's approach and the philosophical depth of the *Federalist* and merit additional study.⁸⁸

Besides offering us guidance in building a more concrete political science, Lonergan's work could play a helpful role in promoting unity in the discipline. His easy familiarity with the methods of the natural sciences and philosophy, and his ability to do justice to each within the bounds of cognitive theory, should

87. *Insight*, p. 236 = CWL 3: 260-261.

88. See David A. Nordquest, "The *Federalist* on Truth and the Constitution," *Polity* 23: 527-47.

engage the interest of political scientists often at odds with one another. Lonergan offers us a shared conceptuality and heuristic—common problems and terms of reference, a common underlying method, and an opportunity for improved mutual comprehension. Few recent works in philosophy are so rich in implications for our work.